MEMORANDUM

TO: Seattle Housing Authority
FROM: Khairy Barnes, Evaluator
DATE: 9/5/2026
SUBJECT: Evaluation of Alice Rhodes and Jobs Plus at Rainier Vista

Summary

The Jobs Plus National Demonstration Project at Rainier Vista should continue for another year, with modifications to how it approaches the residents of the housing project. While Rhodes does bear some responsibility for the program's implementation failures, there are some issues that existed earlier on in the policy cycle, namely in the decision-making process, that also led to the failure of the Jobs Plus National Demonstration Project. Rhodes' discretion to operate as a cultural broker and employment specialist was the appropriate adaptation, given how inaccessible the initial program was to Rainier Vista residents. Rhodes appears to have gone beyond her obligations in both the initial plan and her adapted plan, demonstrating a strong capacity to handle this project. The SHA should therefore support her replacing the WAW; however, Rhodes should also receive additional support. Going forward, the Jobs Plus National Demonstration Project would benefit from hiring people from diverse backgrounds to provide additional support for Rhodes.

What role did Alice Rhodes play in the problems that Jobs Plus encountered?

Rhodes played a role in the problems that Jobs Plus encountered. First, Rhodes had relevant service-delivery and management experience but lacked experience serving a population as culturally and linguistically diverse as Rainier Vista. The ideal candidate for this contract would have been a seasoned employee with more experience outside the company and a resume showing experience working with international immigrants and refugees. Second, she overestimated how many residents would have the ability or desire to attend the sessions. She lacked the cultural awareness and sensitivity to accommodate residents with varying skills and schedules, overlooking the need for an individual approach tailored to each resident's unique experiences, availability, values, and language skills. Third, her outreach, while thoughtful and considerate for immigrant residents, fell short for American-born residents. American-born residents were resistant to the program due to it appearing as an immigrant-only program. Many believed that, because of the focus on immigrant outreach, the program was not meant for them. Lastly, she did not integrate REWA properly into her training for those who struggled with English. While REWA could teach people English, it was limited in job training and couldn't incorporate residents' diverse skills into a job assessment. Rhodes' failure to recognize these problems soon enough led to few people showing up for training and those who did not being adequately supported.

While Rhodes did play a role in the program's problems, WAW also took part of the blame. WAW's personal-transformation model had been successful with a much more specific population, while Rainier Vista required services for residents with different languages, cultures, employment histories, schedules, educational backgrounds, and goals. The standardized WAW

employment curriculum did not adequately account for residents who already possessed professional, technical, or entrepreneurial skills but needed assistance transferring those skills to the U.S. labor market. This means Rhodes could not be primarily blamed, as what she implemented was flawed from the start.

Rhodes's Strategies, Tactics, and Motivations

Despite Rhodes's failures, she still went above and beyond what was required of her. For example, her initial outreach strategy provided tangible benefits. Her tactics involved computer tutorials, "paperwork nights," tax preparation, driving residents to interviews, and dress workshops. She also attended resident gatherings, festivals, and community meetings, and introduced herself to residents while handing out business cards, multilingual flyers, and brochures about the WAW employment training sessions. She appears to have gone the extra mile because of her strong motivation to serve the public. James L. Perry's article "Bringing Society in: Toward a Theory of Public-Service Motivation" (2000) suggests that her motivations stem from her Samaritan characteristic, defined as empathizing with the underprivileged while expecting those they help to also try to help themselves. As a Samaritan, Rhodes finds intrinsic value in providing service. This explanation of motivation goes beyond rational behavior and self-interest and suggests that the sociohistorical and motivational context Rhodes existed in before working for WAW shaped her behavior. Not much is known about Rhodes; however, evidence suggests that her professional training as a manager of wait staff was an important building block for her "taking pride in the notion of serving others" (2).

In addition to going above and beyond in outreach, Rhodes further demonstrates her strong motivation after realizing that the "Personal Transformation" was not effective for the residents of Rainer Vista. However, Rhodes identified issues with her approach and the WAW plan overall and developed a new strategy that incorporated the residents' needs. Rhodes' new strategy was to individualize the program by adding sessions that better suited entrepreneurial residents, incorporating REWA's approach into job training, and attending community events that included American-born residents. Vandenabeele's article, "Toward a Public Administration Theory of Public Service Motivation," adds that while sociohistorical factors could be the root of Rhodes' public service motivation, institutional theory could provide more answers, as these types of socialization are consistent and stable, extend beyond individual and organizational influence, and resemble institutions (547). Additionally, they suggest that self-determination theory could bridge the gap between the institution and Rhodes' public service motivation (549). Rhodes' motivation may stem from identification and integration, arising from a sense of volition within the institution, having internalized its values and being committed to it. As she identified less with the organization's values, broader institutional values of public service were strengthened.

Professional Obligations and the Public Interest

Rhodes' contractual obligation was to implement WAW's model. Jobs Plus's goal was to implement the WAW model, and Rhodes was the agent meant to fulfill it, which she did; however, she also had a broader obligation as a public service agent to serve the public interest and adapt when the model was not serving residents or accomplishing Jobs Plus's goals. When

the obligations between WAW and a service provider responsible to the residents conflict, which is more important? Rhodes's obligation to the residents should take priority if she sticks with Jobs Plus's legitimate goals. Rhodes' decision led her to diverge from the WAW model and take a more individual approach. Her pursuit of public service changed as she analyzed the public interest. In Carol W. Lewis' article, "In Pursuit of the Public Interest" (2006), she frames pursuing public interest as being defined by two demands. One of which is to "reflect on its many facets disclosed through broad representation and dialogue" and "to engage the duties and values associated with four aspects of public interest: democracy, mutuality, sustainability, and legacy" (694). Democracy and mutuality are particularly relevant to this case; Rhodes became increasingly responsive to diverse resident preferences, upholding the democratic aspect. Additionally, Rhodes's choice to prioritize shared welfare over WAW's organizational interests upholds the mutuality aspect. Rhodes demonstrated a strong understanding of the first and second demands by taking accountability for the issues in the first implementation, responding to the needs of all residents after the initial program failure, and then going beyond her obligation to support residents by showing greater empathy for day-to-day issues and providing solutions to issues like childcare, transportation, or unstable work hours so residents can attend the sessions. Ultimately, Rhodes' decision is consistent with Lewis' idea of public interest.

Should SHA Support Rhodes Replacing WAW?

The SHA should support Rhodes' decision to replace WAW, provided clear evaluation criteria are in place to measure her effectiveness, and WAW's inefficiency is documented to avoid scrutiny. Jobs Plus administrators supported Rhodes's adaptive training, while WAW pressured her to return to its personal transformation model. Additionally, WAW denied Rhodes' requests for additional support while using contract funds for central administrative functions. Rhodes' reason for leaving WAW was justified, and WAW proved it could not adapt to residents' needs. Rhodes has shown that her strategies and tactics are effective; she is willing to adapt to residents' needs; she has maintained residents' trust; she has sufficient cultural competence to avoid antagonism; and her motivations align with Jobs Plus objectives. There is reason for concern. Dependence on one individual to guide the program is a large risk, even if she is highly committed. Politically, if other powers hear about the program failure and learn the resolution was to replace the initial company with one of their employees, they will question the SHA's competency. Lastly, and most importantly, there is concern over whether Rhodes has sufficient management capacity. Rhodes is not a seasoned project manager; even if Rhodes has good strategies and tactics, she may not be able to fully handle it alone. While the concerns about Rhodes replacing WAW are understandable, Rhodes displays characteristics akin to what Paarlberg & Lavigna call transformational leadership, based on their article "Transformational Leadership and Public Service Motivation: Driving Individual and Organizational Performance" (2010). Transformational leadership operates on a value-based framework. They clarify organizational purpose, set meaningful goals, and structure work to enhance social impact; all these qualities Rhodes appears to possess. Evidence indicates that transformational leadership positively correlates with better individual performance in public organizations. The question of supporting Rhodes comes down to whether the SHA believes Rhodes is publicly defensible.

Characteristics Needed for Future Jobs Plus Leadership

Going forward, SHA needs a team with cultural and linguistic capacity that reflects the population, combined with demonstrated experience serving diverse communities. This also makes it easier for residents to build trust and develop stronger relationships with public service agents. There is also a need for individualized service delivery so those with different employment needs are accounted for. If the SHA chooses to continue with multiple organizations, it will need a coordinator to effectively incorporate their strengths. It would also be wise for the SHA to allow some independence for those who work directly with residents, as some organizations could pressure their workers to approach residents in ways that may not benefit them. It is important to allow people such as Rhodes to make their own judgment and adjust the plan as circumstances change. Lastly, it is important to have someone from within the community oversee the program's progress. Those with community knowledge can achieve better resident engagement, improve trust in the program, and make outreach more efficient. If the SHA follows these recommendations and Rhodes gets additional support, the program should see much better results.